

Though membership has grown by 13 per cent since 2005, CPI(M) leaders are alarmed that the dropout rate in the stronghold of Kerala was a high 11 per cent

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RED CARPET: General Secretary Prakash Karat being received at a party meet in Kottayam in February

to jump ship, it would have no truck with parties like AIADMK. The political and organisational report adopted at the party congress once again says the Third Alternative does not mean a Third Front or even an electoral alliance. "The formation of the Third front comprising non-Congress, non-BJP parties would not be viable without having a clear alternative set of policies. The party therefore decided that—while not subscribing to the idea of this front—it should maintain relations with SP, TDP or AGP. Our approach should be for a joint stand on issues." At the same time, CPI(M) does not categorically rule out the emergence of a Third Front at the time of the elections. "It has to emerge through joint struggles. It may or may not happen by the next election," said S. Ramachandran Pillai, Politburo member who presented the report at the party meet.

There were other glorious contradictions, particularly relating to

economic policies. Even as the meeting vociferously blasted the "neo-liberal and anti-people reforms" of the Centre, it reminded the 700-odd delegates not to create stumbling blocks for pro-growth policies in states where the party was in power.

Insisting on the need to attract investment, the party congress said: "The people of the Left bastions cannot be told to indefinitely wait for their problems to be addressed till a change takes place at the all-India level...Results have to be delivered to them when compared to other state governments working within the capitalist system." The meeting mentioned the vexing example of special economic zones (SEZ). "While opposing the SEZ Act, we cannot expect Left-led states not to have SEZs. Some SEZs have already been sanctioned in West Bengal. The Smart City project (in Kerala) also has an SEZ status."

It's clear that the party congress

could provide a clear endorsement for the pro-reform forces in the party led by West Bengal Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya, as the conservative minority led by Kerala Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan has been almost totally marginalised. Even after the Singur and Nandigram fiascos, an unapologetic Bhattacharya showed no letup in his campaign in the party for pro-capital reforms and there was no major expression of dissent by the delegates. Aware that he was in a city that probably had more millionaires than Kolkata, Bhattacharya made it a point to meet industrialists in Coimbatore and promised a red-carpet rollout if they came up with plans to invest in Bengal's upcoming textile parks. Bhattacharya's pro-reforms rhetoric was echoed by Asim Dasgupta and Thomas Isaac, the finance ministers of West Bengal and Kerala, respectively, who held out on the need to attract investments.

True to its style as the backseat